ERA 1

Indigenous America

The Peopling of the Americas — to 1491

Pre-Columbian societies · environment · culture

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did geography and environment shape the distinct societies of North America before European contact?

KEY TERMS

Maize · Bering Strait · Cahokia · Iroquois Confederacy · Three Sisters · matrilineal kinship

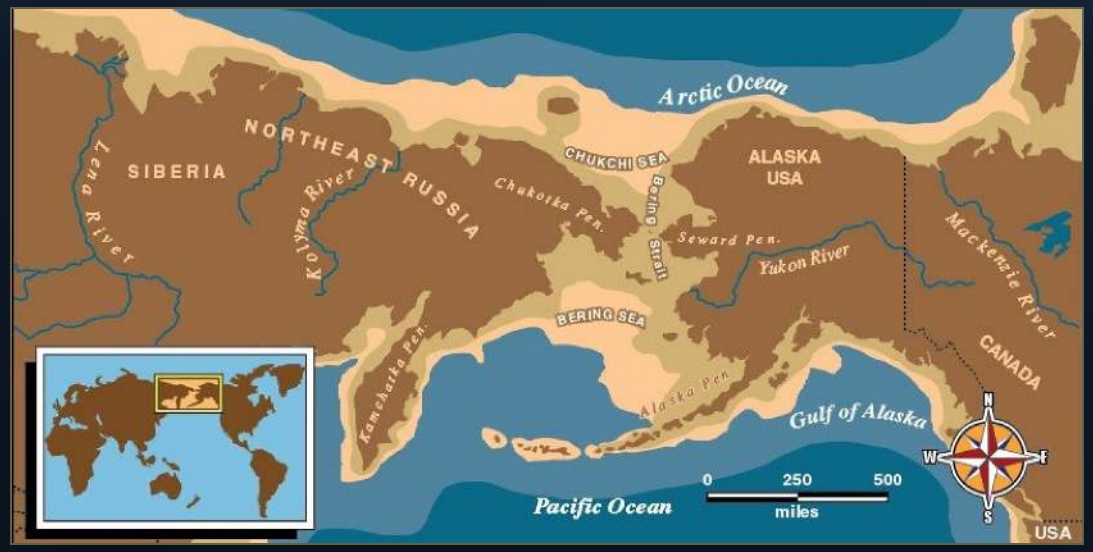
ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 1.1–1.2 · AMSCO Ch. 1.1–1.2

ONE LAND, MANY PEOPLES

Peopling a Continent

The First Migrations



- During the Ice Age, hunters crossed the **Bering Strait Land Bridge** from Asia—roughly 11,000+ years ago.
- Over millennia, peoples spread across the vast expanse of the Americas.
- They developed **distinct, increasingly complex societies**—not one culture, but hundreds.

Why So Different? Environment Shapes Society

START

Environment

Climate, terrain, and resources differ sharply across the continent.

→

THEN

Economy

Each society develops farming, hunting, or fishing to fit its land.

→

RESULT

Distinct Societies

Different economies produce different social and political systems.

THE GREAT EMPIRES

Mesoamerica & the Andes

The Aztecs (Mexica)



- Built a powerful **tribute empire** in central Mexico with a capital, **Tenochtitlan**, of 200,000+.
- An economy rooted in **maize** and intensive farming.
- A stratified society with priests, warriors, and a demanding religion of human sacrifice.

The Inca

- Created the largest **empire** in the Americas—2,000 miles along the Andes.
- United by a single ruler, a vast network of paved roads, and terrace farming.
- A complex administrative state managing millions of people.



SECTION

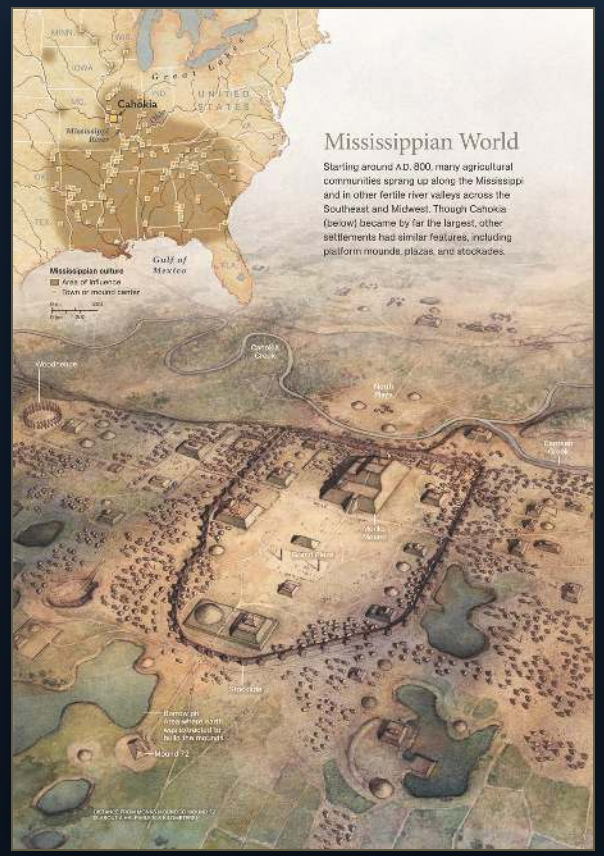
Societies of North America

Peoples of North America

Different environments → different ways of life

PEOPLE · REGION	ENVIRONMENT	ECONOMY	SOCIETY & GOVERNMENT
Mississippian · SE	Fertile river valleys	**Maize** farming; trade hub at **Cahokia**	Hierarchical **chiefdom**; mound cities
Iroquois · NE	Woodlands, rivers, lakes	**Three Sisters** farming & hunting	**Matrilineal**; **Iroquois Confederacy**
Pueblo · SW	Arid desert	Irrigation & **Three Sisters** farming	Settled adobe towns
Great Plains	Open grasslands	**Nomadic buffalo** hunting	Small, mobile bands
Pacific NW & California	Coasts, rivers, forests	Fishing (**salmon**) & gathering	Permanent villages; **potlatch**

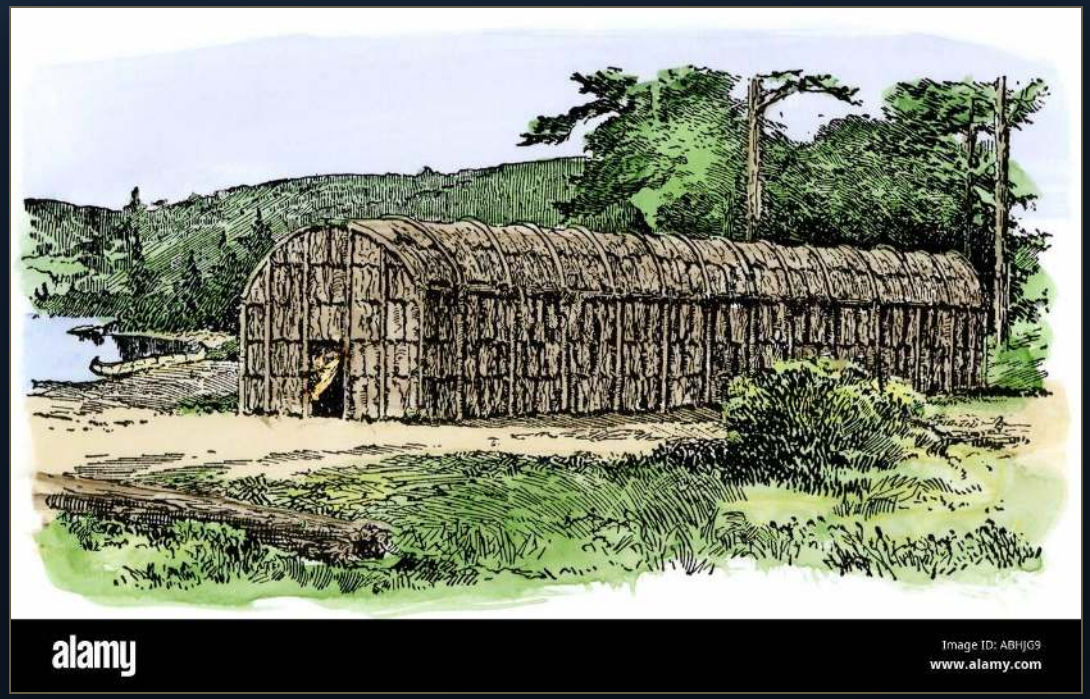
The Mississippians



- Built the largest city north of Mexico—**Cahokia**—with tens of thousands of people.
- Massive earthen mounds anchored a **maize**-based economy and trade network.
- Organized as a **chiefdom** with a clear social hierarchy.

The Iroquois

- Lived in the northeastern woodlands in large, multi-family **longhouses**.
- A **matrilineal** society—status and property traced through women.
- United rival nations under the **Iroquois Confederacy**, a lasting political alliance.



The Pueblo



- Adapted to the arid **Southwest** with advanced irrigation.
- Practiced **Three Sisters** farming—corn, beans, and squash together.
- Built permanent, multi-story towns of adobe (sun-dried brick).

The Great Plains Peoples

- Lived on open grasslands with few rivers or forests.
- Followed a **nomadic** life centered on hunting the **buffalo**.
- Organized in small, mobile bands that could move with the herds.



The Pacific Northwest & California

I

An Abundant Coast

Rich coasts, rivers, and forests provided salmon, game, and acorns.

II

No Need to Farm

Plentiful food let peoples thrive as hunter-gatherers—without agriculture.

III

Complex Villages

They built permanent, populous villages (like the Chinook) and marked status through the **potlatch**.

How Maize Transformed a Continent

ORIGIN

Mesoamerica

Maize (corn) is domesticated in present-day Mexico.

→

SPREAD

Moves North

Maize cultivation spreads into the Southwest and beyond.

→

RESULT

Settled Life

Reliable food supports permanent villages, population growth, and complex societies.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Indigenous America

1. Peoples migrating across North America developed **distinct, increasingly complex societies** by adapting to and transforming their environments.

2. **Geography shaped everything**—**maize** farmers built cities and chiefdoms, Plains peoples followed the **buffalo**, and Pacific peoples thrived by fishing.

3. Long before 1492, the Americas held **millions of people** in hundreds of diverse, sophisticated societies.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Indigenous America

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

COMPARISON

Compare two societies from today (e.g., the Aztecs and the Iroquois). How did their **environments** produce different economic and political systems?

CAUSATION

Explain how the natural environment **caused** ONE society to organize its economy, government, or culture the way it did.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

What developments across the Americas **before 1491** set the stage for the changes Europeans would soon bring?

Up next — **Lesson 2: Contact & Colonization** (European exploration & the Columbian Exchange)